what action to take in case of a Chinese nuclear threat to India, and what to do if India went nuclear.[226]

India, on its part, continued to look for an assurance. One option considered by officials in spring 1967 was to get a declaration associated with a potential nuclear nonproliferation treaty (NPT). On a multicountry visit to explore the question, Jha noted to Rostow that Moscow had agreed to such a declaration, which could be made in parallel with an American announcement when the NPT was signed. It would state that if nonnuclear signatories were at the receiving end of a nuclear threat or attack, the nuclear states would have a responsibility to act through the UN Security Council; furthermore, nuclear states would be allowed to act on this assurance without a prior UN Security Council vote. Jha wanted to gauge American interest in exploring such a parallel declaration with the Soviet Union.[227]

Rostow thought the option was a "real breakthrough." Johnson, however, merely told Jha that the US would study the "very interesting" draft of the potential Soviet declaration. Subsequently, Rusk discussed it with Soviet foreign minister Andrei Gromyko in late June. He was concerned that India seemed to be moving away from linking an assurance with the NPT. Gromyko assured him that Moscow had told Delhi that the two remained linked. Rusk also laid out another problem from the US perspective: needing Senate ratification for any unilateral nuclear assurance. He believed it would be easiest to make an assurance through a UN Security Council resolution. Gromyko, however, noted, that India wanted a more "definite" assurance than a UN Charter–based assurance.[228]

The Indian government wanted an assurance from both superpowers not just to limit criticism at home that it was renouncing nonalignment but as insurance against a change in either superpower's relations with China. Concern about the impact of potential changes in attitude toward China, along with Johnson's short-tether policy, the US and Soviet response during the 1965 war, and deepening Soviet-Pakistan relations had reinforced the Indian sense that the country needed to have multiple friends rather than rely on only one country or bloc.

Indian policymakers were realistic about the slim chances of getting a legal—as opposed to a political—commitment from both countries, especially one that would cover all nonnuclear states. A political guarantee